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FOR CAREER MENTORSHIP
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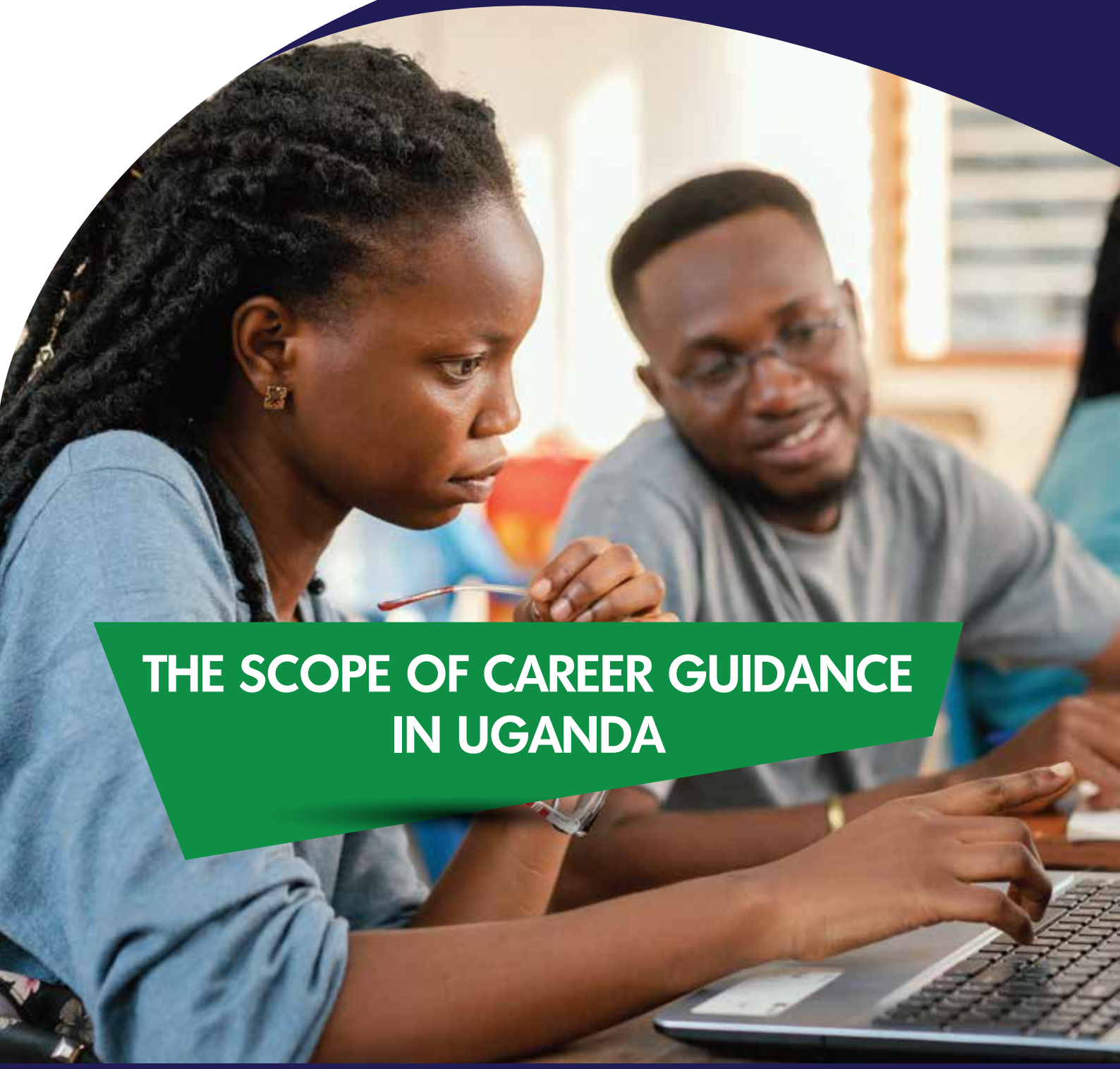

THE SCOPE OF CAREER GUIDANCE IN UGANDA

REPORT

MARCH 2026

AFRICAN CENTER
FOR CAREER MENTORSHIP
"Pursuing your passion"

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

ACCM: African Centre for Career Mentorship
BTVET: Business, Technical, Vocational Education and Training
FUE: Federation of Uganda Employers
MGLSD: Ministry of Gender, Labour and Social Development
MOES: Ministry of Education and Sports
NCHE: National Council for Higher Education
NGO: Non Governmental Organisation
PREC: Professionalism, Research, Excellence, Collaboration
STEM: Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics
TVET: Technical and Vocational Education and Training
UBOS: Uganda Bureau of Statistics
UNESCO: United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organisation
UNICEF: United Nations Children's Fund
URSB: Uganda Registration Services Bureau

OPERATIONAL DEFINITIONS

Career Guidance refers to the structured support provided to individuals to help them understand their abilities, explore opportunities, make informed educational and career choices, and develop the skills necessary to manage their career paths throughout life. For this report, career guidance encompasses career information dissemination, counselling, mentorship, and skills development activities across all educational levels and for out of school populations.

Career Mentorship is a structured relationship in which an experienced professional offers guidance, knowledge, and support to a less experienced individual to facilitate career development, professional growth, and informed decision making.

Scope of Career Guidance describes the breadth and depth of career guidance provision across Uganda's education system and beyond, including the levels at which guidance is provided, the content covered, the duration of guidance sessions, the personnel involved, and the institutional frameworks supporting these activities.

Stratified Career Guidance is an approach that tailors career guidance content, methods, and duration to the specific developmental stage, educational level, and unique needs of learners at different points in their educational journey.

Career Mentors/Teachers are educators, counsellors, and professionals responsible for delivering career guidance services within educational institutions or community settings.

Human Capital Development is the process of acquiring and increasing the knowledge, skills, capabilities, and competencies of individuals to enhance their productivity, employability, and contribution to socio economic development.

Socio Economic Transformation refers to fundamental changes in the social and economic structures of a society that lead to improved livelihoods, reduced inequality, sustainable development, and enhanced quality of life for citizens.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Career guidance in Uganda remains underdeveloped despite being recognised as a critical component of education and workforce development. The African Centre for Career Mentorship (ACCM) conducted a comprehensive survey to understand the scope of career guidance across different educational levels and for out of school populations. This report presents the findings of that survey, which involved participants with no formal education, primary level, lower secondary level, advanced secondary level, tertiary institutions, those who have just immediately finished university, and working-class professionals. The survey identified topics stakeholders consider essential at each stage and the recommended time allocation for career guidance activities.

The results show that career guidance needs are distinct at every level. For those with no formal education, the emphasis is on practical job skills, entrepreneurship, basic literacy and numeracy, and sustainable livelihoods. At the primary level, the focus is on values, creative thinking, exploration of interests, and role models. Lower secondary shifts toward self discovery, career awareness, and entrepreneurial skills. Advanced secondary requires practical job skills, personal branding, higher education pathways, and—critically—mental health support, which emerged as a priority. At the tertiary level, participants highlighted professional ethics, personal branding, online presence, and job application strategies.

Immediately after university, the focus moves to job search strategies, ethics at work, work life balance, and continuous learning. For working-class professionals, leadership, continuous skill enhancement, work life integration, and career transitions are paramount.

The career guidance and training must be stratified by age; career guidance should begin at the primary level; mental health support is required at the advanced secondary level; and professional ethics, personal branding, and online presence should be covered at higher institutions of learning. Based on these findings, the report recommends mainstreaming career guidance in Uganda's education system, employing dedicated career guidance staff at different levels, re orienting existing staff on emerging themes, developing products and services that align with needs, creating more time for career guidance across the board, and extending career guidance to those who did not go to school.

1.0 ABOUT AFRICAN CENTRE FOR CAREER MENTORSHIP (ACCM)

The African Centre for Career Mentorship (ACCM) is a dedicated organisation committed to transforming career guidance and human capital development across Africa.

The vision of ACCM is to create a sustainable Centre of Excellence for Career Mentorship and Human Capital Development in Africa. Its mission is to equip youths and professionals with growing and changing job market skills and support them to discover their full potential for the socio economic transformation of Africa. The organisation operates under four core values encapsulated in the acronym PREC: Professionalism, Research, Excellence, and Collaboration. Professionalism ensures that all interactions with clients, partners, and stakeholders are conducted with integrity, competence, and ethical responsibility.

Research underpins ACCM's evidence based approach, enabling the organisation to understand labour market dynamics, identify gaps, and develop responsive programmes. Excellence drives continuous improvement in service quality and programme effectiveness. Collaboration recognises that career guidance requires multi stakeholder engagement, and therefore ACCM actively partners with government agencies, educational institutions, employers, development organisations, and communities.

ACCM's overall goal is to set up a functional and sustainable Centre of Excellence for Career Mentorship and Human Capital Development in Uganda by December 2025. To achieve this, the organisation has defined several specific objectives, which it calls World Important Goals (WIGs). These include growing a sustainable and accountable organisation by December 2025; developing two career mentorship curricula for STEM and Humanities students leaving universities and colleges in Uganda by June 2024; setting up one career mentorship centre for both STEM and Humanities students leaving universities and colleges by December 2023; initiating career mentorship services for both STEM and Humanities students in the Kampala Metropolitan Area from zero to two million by December 2024; advancing career guidance services for one million students in ten academic institutions and universities in the Kampala Metropolitan Area by December 2025; and designing and implementing a professional human capital development programme for three hundred staff from ten organisations by December 2024.

To track progress, ACCM has established both lag measures and lead measures. The lag measures include having: a fully registered ACCM with seven staff members by December 2025; two career mentorship curricula developed for STEM and Humanities by June 2024; one functional career mentorship centre established in Ntinda, Kampala by December 2023; career guidance services started in ten academic institutions and universities among one million students; and the number of students and professionals accessing career guidance at the ACCM centre reaching two million by 2025. Lead measures, which are the high impact actions that drive the lag measures, include activities such as weekly reading and writing for curriculum development, weekly office and client engagement tasks.

With headquarters in Plot 22, Entebbe Road, 7th Floor Conrad Plaza on top of ISBAT University (City Campus), Kampala, and a growing presence across the continent, ACCM operates as a centre of excellence for career mentorship, equipping youths and professionals with the skills needed to thrive in a rapidly changing job market

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The organisation can be contacted via email at wabelwilson@gmail.com, by telephone at +447570224173, on Twitter at @Mentorglobally, and through its website at https://www.africanccm.com/.

2.0 BACKGROUND FOR CAREER GUIDANCE IN UGANDA

Career guidance in Uganda has long been recognised as an underdeveloped area within the education system. Early research by Nsubuga (2008) documented that schools lacked trained personnel and structured programmes. Despite the growing number of young people entering the workforce each

year, estimated at over 700,000, and the expansion of education at all levels, the link between education and employment remains weak. Graduate unemployment is high, with many young people struggling to find jobs that match their qualifications, and a significant proportion of youth are classified as Not in Education, Employment, or Training (NEET). Employers frequently report that graduates lack practical skills and work readiness, pointing to a persistent mismatch between what is taught in schools and what is required in the labour market.

The structure of Uganda's education system comprises primary level (seven years), lower secondary (four years), advanced secondary (two years), and tertiary education, including universities, colleges, and technical institutions. Each of these levels has distinct career guidance needs, yet current provision is inconsistent and often inadequate.

At the primary level, children rarely receive any formal career exposure, missing the opportunity to build foundational awareness and challenge gender stereotypes. At lower secondary, career guidance, where it exists, tends to focus narrowly on subject selection for the Ordinary Level examinations, with little attention to broader career exploration

The lower secondary school English curriculum covers only two components (choosing a career and applying for a job). Unfortunately, for choosing a career, the curriculum advocates for learners to listen to a tutorial with a career mentor, after which a discussion about it ensues. The question is, how many professional mentors do we have? Where are they located? Where are their offices? This is the void that needs to be fixed urgently. At advanced secondary, the emphasis is almost exclusively on university admission requirements, and mental health support during this high pressure period is almost absent. Tertiary institutions vary widely: some have career services offices, but many do not, and even where they exist, the services often focus only on CV writing and interview preparation, neglecting professional ethics, personal branding, digital presence, and entrepreneurship. After graduation, there is virtually no structured transition support, and workplace career guidance remains rare. Makerere University, for example, every year receives thousands of Year one students who are just admitted, requesting a change of courses. Clearly, this demonstrates the urgency of career guidance at such a level.

But this is hardly done, and many students end up being disappointed and frustrated. In fact, Barigye (2024) argues that in the context of Technical Vocational Education and Training in Uganda, career guidance is important and requires funding, trained personnel, policy, and planning."

Policies such as the Education Act (2008), the TVET Policy (2019), the TVET Act (2025), and the National Development Plan III have all acknowledged the importance of career guidance, but the gap between policy and practice remains wide. Implementation is hampered by a lack of dedicated personnel, inadequate funding, and the absence of a standardised framework for what should be taught and when. This is the gap that the study by the African Centre for Career Mentorship sought to address.

5.0 STRENGTHS, WEAKNESSES, OPPORTUNITIES, AND THREATS (SWOT) OF CAREER GUIDANCE IN UGANDA

We analysed the strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats related to career guidance in Uganda, which provides a picture of the current landscape.

Strengths

- Research-oriented products by Dr. Dan Musinguzi and Abel Walekhwa for the weekly webinars.
- Relatively more visibility for career mentorship sessions and weekly webinars.

  Available and tested tools, frameworks developed by different mentors (Books, AI tools, YouTube Channel, Websites, among others).
- Existing WhatsApp groups for Career mentors and career guidance groups (UG Scholarships Groups).

  Schools, universities and colleges allocate budget lines for career mentorship/inspiration sessions towards the exam period.
- Some parents are concerned and would like to support their students/children.
- Available charity agencies and individuals, like Rotary, are willing to engage in Career guidance programmes.
- Annual National Career Day, which is celebrated at Kololo Independence grounds.

  Multiple stakeholders are engaged in career guidance, including government ministries, development partners like UNICEF and VVOB, non governmental organisations such as ACCM and MasterPeace Uganda, and private sector actors like the Uganda Registration Services Bureau (URSB) and the Federation of Uganda Employers. This multi stakeholder environment brings diverse resources and expertise.
- There are already existing activities that can be built upon, including career days at schools like Gayaza High School and universities such as Gulu University, digital platforms such as UNICEF's FunDoo (which has reached over 30,000 users) and MasterPeace's Job Launchpad WhatsApp based bootcamp.
- The growing digital infrastructure in Uganda, with high mobile phone penetration, offers a scalable channel for delivering career guidance.
- Finally, a growing body of research on career guidance in Uganda provides evidence to inform policy and practice.

Weaknesses

- The most critical is the lack of a standardised career guidance curriculum. Without clear guidance on what to teach and at what stage, career mentors, many of whom are untrained teachers, deliver inconsistent and often inadequate guidance.
- Siloed working among the mentors.
- There are no clear guidelines on content, duration, or delivery methods.
- Most career guidance is provided by teachers who have no specialised training in career development or counselling and who are

already overburdened with other responsibilities.

- Time allocated to career guidance is minimal; it is often limited to occasional career days or assembly talks rather than being integrated into the timetable.
- Resources for career guidance are severely constrained, with little dedicated budget for materials, training, or activities.
- Linkages between educational institutions and employers are weak, leading to outdated labour market information and limited opportunities for internships or work placements.
- Coverage is uneven, with rural schools and disadvantaged communities receiving far less career guidance than urban, well resourced schools.
- Even where guidance exists, critical content areas such as mental health, professional ethics, personal branding, online presence, and entrepreneurship are rarely addressed.
- Career guidance is not stratified by age; the same generic information is often given to primary school children and secondary students alike, ignoring developmental differences.

Opportunities

- Available social media platforms that could be leveraged for information dissemination.
  Weekly free sessions organised for career guidance by different mentors and facilitators.
  Personal Discovery Book written by Abel Walekhwa and published on Amazon.
- Annual career events are organised by professional bodies like the Uganda Law Society, Cavendish University Law Society, the Pharmaceutical Society of Uganda, among others.
- Different individual books written by different authors detailing their career paths and journeys.
- Available WhatsApp group created by Abel Walekhwa with over 70+ career mentors. This is an opportunity to co-create, synergise, and collaborate on different aspects.
- Seasonal and experienced career mentors who have served different agencies and schools over the years, like Mr Henry Nsubuga, Mr Ambrose Kibuuka, Dr. Anita Malinga Muhairwe, among others.
- Available funding opportunities in schools (PTA, Board, USE, UPE), among others
  Existing Alumni/old students' bodies that help to fundraise, engage or offer career guidance based on their lived experiences
- Existing provision for field trips in secondary and primary schools that enables students and pupils to engage with outside audiences and partners to understand what happens beyond their compounds.
- School calendar events like sports day, visitation day could be leveraged among others.
- One of the notable strengths is that career guidance is increasingly recognised in policy documents such as the Education Act, the TVET Policy, and the National Development Plan IV, providing a foundation for further action.
- The current environment presents several opportunities to strengthen career guidance. Recent policy momentum, including the TVET Act 2025 and the National Employment Policy, creates openings for embedding career guidance more deeply in the education system.
- Digital transformation offers low cost, scalable ways to reach young people

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through mobile platforms, and initiatives such as FunDoo and the MasterPeace Job Launchpad demonstrate the potential of digital delivery.

- Public private partnerships can leverage resources and expertise from the private sector; for example, URSB's participation in school career exhibitions shows that private sector organisations are willing to engage.
- The diaspora community represents an underutilised resource for mentorship and investment in skills development.
  National skills competitions such as WorldSkills Uganda promote technical careers and can be used to inspire young people.
- International frameworks like the Sustainable Development Goals (especially SDG 4 on quality education and SDG 8 on decent work) provide impetus and alignment for career guidance initiatives.
- Uganda's large youth population creates a strong demand for career guidance, and young people are increasingly digitally savvy, making them receptive to innovative delivery methods.

Threats

- Negative perceptions of technical and vocational education persist; many parents and students view TVET as a fallback for those who fail academically, limiting its attractiveness as a career pathway.
- High youth unemployment: With estimates of graduate unemployment as high as 88 percent in some sectors, this can create cynicism about the value of career guidance and lead young people to feel that guidance is disconnected from reality.
- Fiscal constraints affect government budgets, limiting funding for career guidance programmes and public sector recruitment, which traditionally absorbed many graduates.
- Global funding shifts, including reductions in international development assistance, may affect NGO programmes and development partner support.
- Some employers are reluctant to hire and train inexperienced graduates or to engage with educational institutions on curriculum development.
- Technological barriers, such as uneven Internet connectivity and limited device access, can exclude disadvantaged youth from digital career guidance services.
- Brain drain of skilled professionals may reduce the pool of potential career mentors.
- Political instability in the region could disrupt education systems and affect economic conditions that influence employment.

3.0 MOTIVATION FOR THIS STUDY

The motivation for this study is grounded in the strategic plan of the African Centre for Career Mentorship. ACCM's goal of establishing a Centre of Excellence for Career Mentorship which requires a clear understanding of the current state of career guidance in Uganda. The strategic plan identifies specific objectives that depend on this understanding. For example, developing two career mentorship curricula for STEM and Humanities students necessitates knowing what content is already covered, what gaps exist, and what stakeholders need. Setting up a career mentorship centre and advancing career guidance services to one million students across ten institutions requires evidence on where and how to intervene most effectively.

Designing professional development programmes for staff from ten organisations demands knowledge of the competencies that career mentors currently lack. Advocacy efforts with the Ministry of Education and Sports and the National Council for Higher Education are strengthened when they are backed by empirical evidence from a well designed study.

Beyond the strategic needs of ACCM, there is a broader demand from practitioners and policymakers. The UG Career Mentors WhatsApp group, which currently has 23 members comprising career guidance practitioners from schools, universities, NGOs, and government, regularly discusses the challenges they face. Members report that they have no clear guidance on what content to deliver at different educational levels, how much time to allocate, and how to address emerging themes such as digital careers, mental health, and personal branding.

This group represents a community of professionals who are eager for standardisation and clarity. The current study is designed to provide exactly that: a clear, evidence based understanding of the scope of career guidance in Uganda, with actionable recommendations that will inform curricula, training, and policy.

4.0 OBJECTIVES OF THE STUDY

The overall objective of this study was to understand the scope of career guidance in Uganda across different educational levels and for out of school populations. Specifically, the study sought to gather perspectives from individuals at various stages—those with no formal education, primary level, lower secondary level, advanced secondary level, tertiary institutions, those immediately after university or institution, and working class professionals—to identify what topics should be covered at each stage and how much time should be allocated. The study also aimed to generate recommendations for standardising and strengthening career guidance provision in Uganda.

5.0 METHODOLOGY

The survey on the scope of career guidance in Uganda was designed as a quantitative, cross sectional study aimed at capturing stakeholder perspectives on career guidance content, timing, and delivery across different educational levels. The study was conducted entirely virtually between June and September 2023, leveraging digital platforms to reach a geographically dispersed sample of recent graduates, early career professionals, and career mentors.

Target population and sampling. The primary target population was university leavers – individuals who had graduated from Ugandan universities or tertiary institutions within the preceding five years (2018–2023). Additionally, the survey included working-class professionals (0–7 years of experience), career guidance teachers, and a small number of individuals with no formal education (accessed through community networks). A purposive snowball sampling strategy was employed: initial contacts were identified through ACCM's existing WhatsApp communities (18 groups, 14,890 members) and the UG Career Mentors WhatsApp group (23 members). Invitations to participate were then shared virally, resulting in a final sample of 94 respondents.

Data collection via online webinar presentations: A distinctive feature of the methodology was the integration of live, interactive webinar presentations. ACCM

hosted three weekly Thursday mentorship webinars (for 90 minutes) focused on career guidance gaps in Uganda. During these webinars, the research team presented preliminary findings from an initial literature review and posed structured questions to attendees. Participants provided real time input and feedback via Zoom polls, chat comments, and a shared Google Form. This interactive process allowed the research team to refine survey questions, validate emerging themes, and ensure that the instrument captured locally relevant topics. After each webinar, a revised survey link was distributed to all participants and their networks.

Online research and literature review: Concurrently, the research team conducted an online desk review of existing literature on career guidance in Uganda and sub Saharan Africa. Key sources included peer reviewed articles (e.g., Nsubuga, 2008; Otwine et al., 2025), policy documents (Education Act 2008, TVET Policy 2019, National Development Plan III), and grey literature from development partners (UNICEF, VVOB, WorldSkills Uganda). This review informed the development of a structured questionnaire covering: (a) career guidance experiences at each educational level, (b) perceived importance of 25 content topics, (c) recommended duration of guidance, and (d) open ended suggestions.

Survey administration: The final questionnaire (45 items) was programmed into Google Forms and distributed via WhatsApp, email, and LinkedIn. The survey remained open for six weeks, with weekly reminders. All responses were anonymous, and informed consent was obtained via a checkbox on the first page. Data were exported to Excel and analysed using descriptive statistics (frequencies, percentages, means) and thematic analysis of open ended comments.

Integration of stakeholder feedback: Throughout the process, feedback from webinar participants was incorporated into the survey instrument and subsequent analysis. For example, initial drafts omitted "mental health and well being" as a topic for advanced secondary level; after multiple webinar attendees raised this gap, the topic was added. Similarly, the recommended duration ranges (e.g., 2–10 hours per level) were adjusted based on participant input, leading to the final figures reported in Table 1.

6.0 RESULTS

The survey conducted by ACCM gathered responses from 94 participants across seven categories: individuals with no formal education, those who completed primary level only, lower secondary level, advanced secondary level, tertiary institutions (colleges and universities), those immediately after university, and working-class professionals. For each category, participants were asked to identify the topics they considered most important for career guidance at that stage, and to suggest the recommended duration of guidance in hours.

Table 1: The summary of Career Guidance Scope in Uganda (2023)

Educational Level	Topics	Frequency(n)	Percentage	(%)Recommended
No Formal Education	Practical job skills, entrepreneurship, income generation	47	50	6
	Basic literacy and numeracy,basic digital literacy, vocational skills and training	25	27	5
	Financial literacy and problem-solving and critical thinking	8	9	4
	Sustainable agriculture and livelihoods, community development and leadership	7	7	5
	Personal empowerment, cultural skills and knowledge, confidence	4	4	8
	Health and well-being, networking and community support	3	3	4
Primary Level	Values, creative thinking, problem-solving, traits	34	36	10
	Exploration of interests,future possibilities, talents	29	31	5
	Personal development, basic life skills, cultural awareness,diversity	21	22	3

Educational Level	Topics	Frequency(n)	Percentage	(%)Recommended
	Personal development, basic life skills, cultural awareness,diversity	21	22	3
	Role models, inspirational figures, ethics,social responsibility	10	11	2
Lower Secondary	Self-discovery, exploration, career awareness, academic pathways, goal setting	47	50	8
	Entrepreneurship and innovation, digital literacy and technology	21	22	4
	Educational opportunities, skills development, personal branding, networking	16	17	5
	Practical job skills	9	10	3
	Cultural sensitivityand global perspective, decision making, resilience	1	1	–
Advanced Secondary	Practical job skills, skill development, portfolio building, personal branding, online presence	31	33	10
	Higher education and career pathways, self-discovery, self-assessment	24	26	9

Educational Level	Topics	Frequency(n)	Percentage	(%)Recommended
	Entrepreneurship and innovation, financial literacy, scholarships	19	20	6
	College and university selection, career research, exploration	15	16	4
	Networking and professional connections, internships, work experience	4	4	3
	Mental health and well-being	1	1	3
Institutions (Colleges, Universities)	Job application strategies, interview strategies, job market trends and skills mapping, professional development planning,practical job skills and tools	35	37	5
	Professional ethics and values, personal branding and online presence, transition to the workforce, entrepreneurship	32	34	6
	Goal refinement and alignment, industry insight, networking	14	15	7
	Mentoring and peer support, networking, relationship building	8	9	5
	Higher education and career pathways, self-discovery, self-assessment	24	26	9

Educational Level	Topics	Frequency(n)	Percentage	(%)Recommended
	Entrepreneurship and innovation, financial literacy, scholarships	19	20	6
	College and university selection, career research, exploration	15	16	4
	Networking and professional connections, internships, work experience	4	4	3
	Mental health and well-being	1	1	3
Institutions (Colleges, Universities)	Job application strategies, interview strategies, job market trends and skills mapping, professional development planning,practical job skills and tools	35	37	5
	Professional ethics and values, personal branding and online presence, transition to the workforce, entrepreneurship	32	34	6
	Goal refinement and alignment, industry insight, networking	14	15	7
	Mentoring and peer support, networking, relationship building	8	9	5
	Leadership and management skills, financial literacy and planning	5	5	5

Educational Level	Topics	Frequency(n)	Percentage	(%)Recommended
Immediately After University	Ethics at work, work-life balance and well-being, continuous learning and up skilling	25	27	5
	Job search, application strategies, transition to workforce or postgraduate studies	21	22	6
	Entrepreneurship and innovation, financial planning and management	20	21	8
	Personal and professional growth,professional networking	18	19	9
	Public speaking and communication skills, global perspective, cultural sensitivity	5	5	10
	Long-term career planning	4	5	10
Working Class Professionals	Leadership and management skills, continuous learning and skill enhancement, ethical leadership, integrity	36	38	3
	Work-life integration and well-being, entrepreneurship and side ventures, financial planning and wealth management	26	28	2
	Career transitions and pivots, career reflection and assessment, professional networking and relationship building	5	5	1

Educational Level	Topics	Frequency(n)	Percentage	(%)Recommended
	Global perspective and cross-cultural competence, personal branding and reputation management	9	10	5
	trategic career planning, professional resilience and adaptability	5	5	1

7.0 Discussions

The results consolidated in Table 1 provide a stratified framework for career guidance across the entire educational and professional spectrum in Uganda. Each level has distinct content priorities and recommended time allocations, reflecting the developmental and contextual needs of learners and workers.

For individuals with no formal education, the emphasis is on practical job skills, entrepreneurship, and basic literacy and numeracy. This recognises that out of school youth and adults require immediate, applicable skills to generate income and improve their livelihoods. The recommended total of 32 hours suggests that career guidance for this group must be delivered through intensive, community based programmes rather than occasional workshops.

At the primary level, the focus on values, creative thinking, and exploration of interests aligns with the principle that career guidance should begin early. Children need to develop foundational traits and explore possibilities before they are tracked into specific subjects. The recommended 20 hours of guidance, integrated across the primary curriculum, would provide consistent exposure to the world of work and help challenge gender stereotypes that often limit aspirations.

Lower secondary shifts toward self discovery and career awareness. The highest priority is helping students understand themselves and connect that understanding to academic pathways and goals. The inclusion of entrepreneurship and digital literacy reflects the growing recognition that these skills are essential for all careers. The recommended 20 hours at this stage would support students as they make critical subject choices that shape their future options. These hours could be structured across the term, but also having a go-to office for career guidance is an important systematic effort for this.

Advanced secondary (A-level) presents the most intensive needs, with a total recommended duration of 35 hours. The top priorities—practical job skills, personal branding, online presence, and higher education pathways—reflect the dual challenge of preparing for both tertiary education and direct entry into the workforce. Notably, mental health and well being, though mentioned by only one participant, was

recommended for 3 hours. This finding supports the take home message that mental health support is required at A' level, where students face overwhelming pressure from examinations and family expectations. The low frequency may indicate that the topic was not prominently prompted, but those who raised it recognised its critical importance.

At the tertiary level (institutions), the results highlight the need for guidance on job market preparation, professional ethics, personal branding, and online presence. These topics are essential for transitioning from education to employment. The recommended total of 28 hours indicates that career guidance should be a mandatory component of tertiary programmes, not an optional add on. The inclusion of networking, industry insight, and leadership skills further aligns with employer demands for graduates who are not only technically competent but also professionally ready.

For those just out of university, the focus shifts to ethics at work, work life balance, continuous learning, and job search strategies. The recommended total of 48 hours is the highest among all groups, reflecting the intense needs of graduates navigating the transition to employment or further study. The emphasis on entrepreneurship and financial planning also indicates that many graduates are considering self employment as a viable path in a context of limited formal job opportunities.

Finally, working-class professionals require guidance on leadership, continuous skill enhancement, work life integration, and career transitions. The recommended total of 15 hours, spread over several sessions, acknowledges that professionals have limited time but need targeted support to advance their careers and adapt to changing labour market conditions. The inclusion of a global perspective and cross cultural competence reflects the increasing importance of international exposure and adaptability.

The messages—stratification by age, beginning at primary level, mental health support at A-level, and covering professional ethics and personal branding at tertiary—are all echoed in the content and durations detailed in Table 1. The recommendations to mainstream career guidance, employ dedicated staff, re orient existing staff, create more time, and extend guidance to out of school populations provide a clear implementation pathway.

The existence of the UG Career Mentors WhatsApp group, with its 72 members, underscores the urgency of these recommendations. Practitioners are actively seeking clarity and sharing resources in the absence of a national framework. The detailed content and duration guidance in Table 1 directly address that gap, providing career mentors with a clear roadmap of what to teach and for how long at each stage.

8.0 CONCLUSIONS

The findings confirm that career guidance is currently underdeveloped, fragmented, and lacking a standardised framework. The results, summarised in Table 1, reveal that stakeholders at every level, from individuals with no formal education to working professionals, have distinct and urgent needs that are not being met by existing provision. The key take home messages from the study are that career guidance

must be stratified by age, must begin at the primary level, must include mental health support at the advanced secondary level, and must cover professional ethics, personal branding, and online presence at higher institutions of learning.

The survey data provide a clear roadmap for what should be taught and for how long at each stage. For those with no formal education, practical job skills, entrepreneurship, and basic literacy are paramount. At the primary level, the focus should be on values, exploration of interests, and role models. Lower secondary students need self discovery, career awareness, and entrepreneurial skills. Advanced secondary requires practical job skills, personal branding, higher education pathways, and mental health support. Tertiary institutions must prioritise job application strategies, professional ethics, personal branding, and online presence. Immediately after university, graduates need guidance on ethics at work, work life balance, job search, and entrepreneurship. Working professionals require leadership, continuous learning, work life integration, and career transition support.

These findings are not merely academic; they respond directly to the challenges raised by career mentors themselves, many of whom are members of the UG Career Mentors WhatsApp group (72 members) and who have consistently reported that they lack clarity on what to teach and when. The study fills that gap by providing a stratified content framework and recommended durations, thereby enabling a coherent, coordinated approach to career guidance across Uganda.

9.0 RECOMMENDATIONS FOR STAKEHOLDERS

Based on the conclusions of this study, the following recommendations are addressed to specific stakeholder groups. Each set of recommendations is drawn from the survey findings and is designed to be actionable within the mandate and capacity of the respective stakeholders.

9.1 Recommendations for the Ministry of Education and Sports

1. Mainstream career guidance as a core component of the curriculum. The Ministry should revise the national curriculum framework to integrate career guidance across all levels of education, using the content and duration guidelines in Table 1 as the standard. Career guidance should be timetabled, not treated as an occasional add on.

2. Develop and mandate age stratified career guidance curricula: The National Curriculum Development Centre, under the Ministry's oversight, should develop detailed curricula for primary, lower secondary, and advanced secondary levels that specify the topics, learning outcomes, and time allocations identified in this study. These curricula should be mandatory for all schools.

3. Establish staffing standards for career guidance: The Ministry should issue a policy requiring every primary school to have at least one trained career guidance teacher (or a shared resource for small schools), every secondary school to have a dedicated career guidance department with qualified counsellors, and every tertiary institution to have a career services office with professional staff. These standards should be included in school inspection frameworks.

4. Allocate dedicated budget and time: The Ministry should ensure that career guidance receives adequate funding in the education budget and that schools allocate the recommended hours from Table 1 (e.g., 20 hours per year at primary and lower secondary, 35 hours at advanced secondary) within the timetable.

5. Coordinate national career guidance efforts: The Ministry should establish or designate a national career guidance coordination body that brings together government, development partners, NGOs, the private sector, and practitioners (including the UG Career Mentors WhatsApp group) to ensure alignment, share resources, and monitor progress.

9.2 Recommendations for the National Council for Higher Education (NCHE)

1. Incorporate career guidance into quality assurance standards: NCHE should revise its accreditation and quality assurance frameworks to require that all higher education institutions (universities, colleges, and other tertiary institutions) have a functional career services office with qualified staff. The standards should specify that career guidance programmes cover the topics identified in Table 1 for institutions, including professional ethics, personal branding, online presence, job application strategies, and entrepreneurship.

2. Mandate a minimum duration for career guidance: NCHE should require that each undergraduate and graduate programme include a minimum of 28 hours of structured career guidance (as per Table 1) over the course of study, integrated into the curriculum either as a dedicated module or as embedded activities.

3. Monitor and evaluate career services: NCHE should include career services as a key indicator in institutional audits and require institutions to report on career guidance activities, student participation, and outcomes such as graduate employment rates.

4. Promote professional development for career staff: NCHE should work with institutions to ensure that career services staff receive ongoing training on emerging themes such as digital career platforms, mental health support, and labour market trends.

9.3 Recommendations for Universities, Colleges, and Head Teachers

1. Implement the stratified content framework: Institutions should adopt the career guidance topics and recommended durations from Table 1 for their respective levels. For secondary schools, this means introducing career guidance at primary feeder schools, building a coherent programme from primary through advanced secondary. For tertiary institutions, it means integrating the topics for institutions and immediately after university into their programmes.

2. Establish or strengthen career services: Every university and college should have a dedicated career services office with trained professionals. Secondary schools should appoint a career guidance department with at least one trained teacher who is not overburdened with other subjects. Head teachers should ensure that career guidance is timetabled and resourced.

Allocate time and resources: Head teachers should ensure that the recommended hours from Table 1 are protected in the school timetable. University leadership should allocate budget for career services, including materials, technology, and external partnerships.

4. Develop partnerships with employers and alumni: Institutions should create formal linkages with employers to provide internships, mentorship, guest lectures, and job placement opportunities. Alumni networks should be mobilised to serve as mentors and role models.

5. Provide mental health support at advanced secondary: Secondary schools should integrate mental health and well being into career guidance at A' level, as recommended in Table 1. This may involve training career teachers in basic mental health first aid and establishing referral pathways to counselling services.

6. Use the survey results to inform curriculum development: Institutions that have flexibility in their curriculum should use the detailed topic lists in Table 1 to design career guidance modules, workshops, and resources that are age appropriate and context relevant.

9.4 Recommendations for Career Mentors in Uganda

1. Adopt the stratified content guidelines: Career mentors could use Table 1 as a reference for what to teach at each level. This will ensure consistency across the country and help mentors move beyond improvisation.

2. Develop age appropriate products and services: Using the topics and recommended durations, career mentors should create or adapt resources—such as lesson plans, activity sheets, digital content, and workshop modules—that align with the needs of their target group. For example, primary level mentors should focus on values and exploration, while tertiary mentors should develop modules on personal branding and professional ethics.

3. Seek continuous professional development: Career mentors should pursue training on emerging themes such as digital career platforms, labour market information, mental health support, and entrepreneurship. They should also engage with networks like the UG Career Mentors WhatsApp group to share best practices and resources.

4. Advocate for time and resources: Career mentors should work with school administrators and institutional leaders to secure the recommended time allocation and necessary resources. They should present the evidence from this study to make a compelling case for prioritising career guidance.

5. Collaborate with employers and alumni: Mentors should actively build relationships with local employers, professional associations, and alumni to bring real world perspectives into career guidance sessions. They should organise career talks, workplace visits, and mentorship programmes.

6. Integrate mental health and well being: Especially for those working with advanced secondary and tertiary students, career mentors should incorporate mental health awareness into their sessions, creating safe spaces for students to discuss stress, anxiety, and pressures related to career decisions.

7. Leverage Artificial Intelligence (AI) for career mentorship: AI is in our society and can be used in career guidance. Mentors should develop AI tools such as AI assistants to enhance the mentoring experience. It is important that mentors design such tools that are safe to use by their mentees. Both the mentors and mentees should read and understand UNESCO's AI competency frameworks for students and teachers. Similarly, the country's AI documents and those of enamouring countries should be embraced as they provide the direction where AI is headed, and this should be part of career guidance.

9.5 Recommendations for Students and Young People

1. Take ownership of your career development: Recognise that career guidance is a resource, but ultimately, your career is your responsibility. Actively seek out, participate in career guidance sessions, ask questions, and seek out additional information.

2. Explore diverse pathways: Use the topics covered in career guidance to explore not only traditional university routes but also TVET, entrepreneurship, apprenticeships, and self employment. Uganda's labour market offers many opportunities beyond the formal sector.

3. Develop a strong personal brand: Start building your personal brand early—through a professional online presence, a well crafted CV, and a clear articulation of your strengths and values. Use social media responsibly and be aware of your digital footprint.

4. Prioritise your mental health: The advanced secondary and tertiary years can be stressful. Seek support from career mentors, counsellors, or trusted adults when you feel overwhelmed. Balance ambition with self care.

5. Network and seek mentors: Connect with professionals in fields you are interested in, join student organisations, attend career events, and use platforms like LinkedIn to build your network. Mentors can provide invaluable guidance and open doors to opportunities.

6. Embrace lifelong learning: The world of work is constantly changing. Be prepared to continuously upskill, whether through short courses, online learning, or on the job training. The topics in Table 1 for working professionals—continuous learning, leadership, and adaptability—are relevant even while you are still in school. Most importantly, do not wait to be given information or told what needs to be done. Conduct extensive research on your own and discover answers or solutions to your current questions or challenges.

7. .Advocate for better career guidance. If your school or institution does not provide adequate career guidance, speak up. Form student groups to request career services, and share this report with your teachers and administrators to demonstrate what is needed.

10.0 LIMITATIONS OF THE SURVEY

The survey has several limitations that should be considered when interpreting the results. However, these limitations are valuable because they provide areas for future research to help fully understand the career guidance landscape in Uganda. Needless to mention, future studies should address the following limitations associated with this study.

1. Small sample size and non probability sampling: With only 94 respondents, the sample is relatively small and was selected through convenience and snowball sampling. This limits the generalisability of findings to all Ugandan career guidance stakeholders. The sample may overrepresent individuals who are already engaged with ACCM's digital platforms (WhatsApp groups, webinars) and thus have higher than average awareness of career guidance issues.

2. Virtual only data collection: Conducting the survey entirely online excluded individuals without reliable internet access, smartphones, or digital literacy. This is particularly relevant for rural populations, older professionals, and those with no formal education – groups that are arguably most in need of career guidance. The under representation of these voices may bias the results toward urban, digitally connected perspectives.

3. Self reported and recall bias: Participants were asked to recall their career guidance experiences from primary school through university, which for some respondents occurred many years ago. Memory decay and retrospective reinterpretation may have affected accuracy. Additionally, respondents may have over reported the importance of certain topics (e.g., mental health) because they were discussed during webinars (social desirability bias).

4. Lack of randomisation and control group: The survey was descriptive, not experimental. Therefore, we cannot attribute any observed outcomes (e.g., career transitions) directly to specific guidance content. The recommended durations and topics are based on stakeholder opinion, not causal evidence.

5. Potential facilitator influence: The webinars were hosted by ACCM staff, who have a vested interest in demonstrating the need for expanded career guidance. Although efforts were made to remain neutral, participants may have felt pressure to endorse topics that align with ACCM's strategic priorities (e.g., AI, personal branding).

6. Limited geographic coverage: All the respondents were from Uganda. Thus, findings are most applicable for Uganda and may not fully reflect conditions in Francophone or North African contexts.

7. No pilot testing of the questionnaire: Due to time constraints, the final questionnaire was not pilot tested on a separate sample before full deployment. This may have introduced ambiguous wording or omitted important response options.

Despite these limitations, the survey provides a valuable, stakeholder informed baseline for understanding the scope of career guidance in Uganda. Future research should employ probability sampling, mixed mode data collection (including offline methods), and longitudinal designs to validate and extend these findings.

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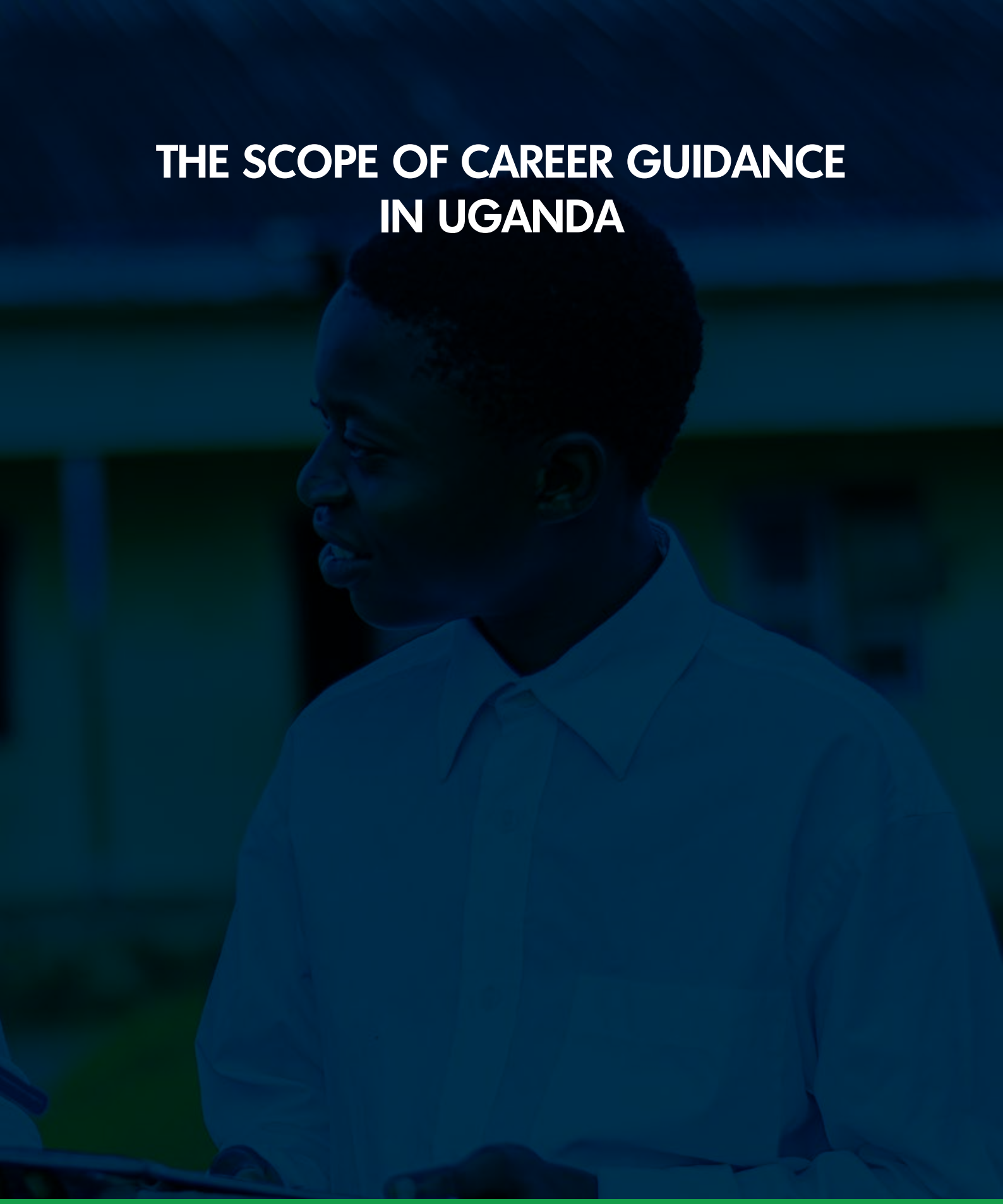

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